

Accuse and blame

Learner workbook

Distinguish an allegation from an assignment of responsibility.

Understand the distinction

Accuse someone of something means say that the person did something wrong: accuse someone of lying. Blame someone for something assigns responsibility: blame the supplier for a delay.

An accusation is a claim, not proof. Use alleged, said, or according to when reporting an unestablished claim. In a practical discussion, describing an observed problem and asking for an explanation can be more useful than assigning blame.

Compare the patterns

ACCUSE OF

They accused him of sharing the file.

They claimed he did something wrong.

BLAME FOR

They blamed the delay on a missed delivery.

This assigns a cause.

OBSERVE

The file arrived after the deadline.

This states an observable event.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Complete: She accused him ___ copying.

A. to

B. for

C. of

2. Complete: They blamed me ___ the mistake.

A. for

B. of

C. at

3. Does was accused of prove that someone did it?

A. No. It proves the person did not do it.

B. No. It reports an allegation.

C. Yes. An accusation proves the action happened.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. You only know that the report arrived late. Which response gives that observation and asks for missing information?

- A. The report arrived after the deadline because you ignored it.
- B. You deliberately delayed the report. Why did you do that?
- C. The report arrived after the deadline. What caused the delay?

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. of

The pattern is accuse someone of something.

2. A. for

Use blame someone for something.

3. B. No. It reports an allegation.

Keep the distinction between a claim and an established fact.

4. C. The report arrived after the deadline. What caused the delay?

This states the observed fact and asks about the cause without assigning blame.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-24.html